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How many interviews do I have to clear to get a job?

It is usually a minimum of two interviews: a technical interview and an HR interview. In some cases (e.g., if the company you've applied to is in another city or country), a telephonic interview is done to screen the candidates before calling them for face-to-face interviews. In major Indian IT companies and MNCs that are product-based, there will be multiple technical interviews. Unless the hiring company is satisfied with your technical skills (and communication skills) and you clear the HR interview, you cannot get the job. Your social status makes no impact in the interviews.

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Why do companies have an HR interview in addition to the technical interview(s)?

The HR interview has two objectives—(1) to check if you're fit for the organisation; and (2) to check if your requirements match that of the organisation. If you have good communication skills, a friendly personality, a positive attitude, and keen interest in learning and contributing, and in addition, if you're an effective team player and it is likely that you'll stay for at least a few years, it's most likely that you will be beneficial to the organisation. An HR interview is intended to check all these aspects. In other words, an HR interview checks your soft skills, attitude, and if you're the 'right fit' for the company.

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Why is an HR interview important?

Simple—only if you clear this interview, you'll get a job! Also, if you get the job, the HR department (of course, after consulting with the manager of the team for which you're recruited) decides the pay you'll get, your roles and responsibilities, etc.

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I am a class topper. Should I attend only selective companies in our campus interviews because I am sure to get a job?

You're overconfident and this can spoil your chances of getting a job. Being a class topper obviously gives you a better chance of getting a job. But remember, the skills required for getting a job are different from getting high marks. It is better to get a job first and then start being selective about your 'dream company', which you may want to join as a second job. Also, if you're selective, you lose opportunities to attempt written tests and interviews and hence when your 'dream company' comes for placement, you'll be ill-prepared for it.

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I got a job, but I did not get a call to join the company. Should I keep on waiting indefinitely?

Don't worry. If the job environment is bad, it is natural that your joining date can be very late (in some cases, the delay can be more than a year!). Keep in touch with the HR department of the concerned company and get to know the status from other candidates who have got placed in that company. Explore other alternatives: search for another job (who knows, you might be destined for a better job!); join some job-oriented courses; do certifications in the areas of your interest

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That brings me to another question. Do certifications help in getting a job?

Yes. Today certifications are an effective way to demonstrate your expertise in a particular technical domain. Getting relevant, valuable certifications can significantly improve your chances of getting a well-paid job.

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